

for greater safety after the Viet Cong breached the Tan Son Nhut compound in 1967. Captain Peggy Ready was the first Detachment commander in Vietnam, and Marion Crawford was her First Sergeant.

Officers who agreed to have female staff members discovered that these women were not only highly competent, but would work long hours without complaint. The women took on a variety of roles, serving as intelligence analysts, translators, clerk-typists, flight controllers, couriers, physical therapists, or photographers.

Soon, many of the male holdouts wanted women assigned to their staff, even though senior military leaders did not believe women, other than nurses, should serve in a combat zone. Their success brought more women from the Air Force, Marine Corps, and Navy.

These first women arrived in country wearing dress uniforms. Most were untrained in weapons use, but all were willing to serve. Within a year, they were wearing jungle fatigues, boots, and helmets, and knew the fastest route to their bunkers during rocket attacks.

200 The number of women who served with the USAF in Vietnam.
35 The number of US women who served with the US Marine Corps.



WAF pioneers

Lt. Col. Frances Chaffin (left) greets the first five enlisted Air Force (WAF) women and fourth WAF officer to arrive in Vietnam: June Hilton, Carol Hornick, Rita Pitcock, Barbara Snaveley, Shirley J. Brown, and Eva Nordstrom.